

800 ▶ 945



Gathering of scholars at the House of Wisdom, Baghdad

810

The House of Wisdom

The Bayt al-Hikma, or House of Wisdom, was founded in Baghdad (now in Iraq) in the early 9th century. It housed an enormous library and was used by scholars working on translating Greek scientific texts into Arabic.

Woodblock printed page from the *Diamond Sutra*

868

The *Diamond Sutra*

In the 9th century, the Chinese invented the technique of printing books using single carved wooden blocks for each page. The *Diamond Sutra*, a Buddhist religious text discovered in 1907, is the oldest complete example of a book produced in this way. One of the pages bears its date—May 11, 868.



▶▶ 800

In 843, Irish theologian John Scotus Eriugena suggested that the planets Mercury, Venus, Mars, and Jupiter orbit the Sun.

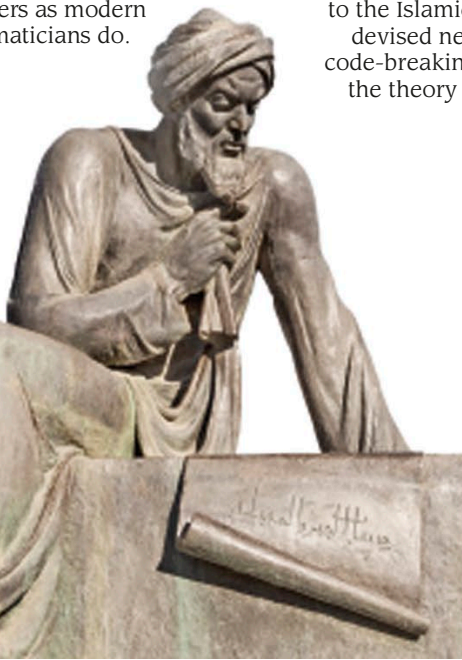


830

Birth of algebra

The Arab mathematician al-Khwarizmi published a book describing the type of mathematics now known as algebra. He introduced an important idea for working out equations, although he did not use letters to represent numbers as modern mathematicians do.

Statue of al-Khwarizmi in Uzbekistan



845

al-Kindi's numerals

Abu Yusuf al-Kindi, an Arab mathematician and scholar from Basra (now in Iraq), wrote hundreds of books. Among them was his work on Indian numerals (on which modern numerals are based), which he introduced to the Islamic world. He also devised new techniques in code-breaking, and wrote on the theory of parallel lines.

850



Ancient Chinese soldier prepares to fire arrows propelled by gunpowder.

855

Discovery of gunpowder

In the mid-9th century, Chinese alchemists were searching for an elixir of life using saltpeter. They found instead that when this chemical was mixed with sulfur and charcoal, it created an explosive substance: gunpowder. Within 50 years it was being used to propel rockets (see p.53).